

Customer Journey Map

Purpose

Last week you defined your problem and who the product is for.

This week we will deepen that understanding by exploring how the problem shows up in a user's life. This will give us a realistic view of the user's experience and ensure our future solutions are grounded in empathy for the user and their problem.

Assignment

Create one user persona representing your primary user.

Re-read your problem statement, product vision, and success definition from last week.

Confirm your primary user.

Define your persona:

Student actively developing and defending academic arguments under time pressure

- **Role**

- What is this person responsible for in this situation?
- What role best explains *why* they encounter this problem?
- Is this a role someone would recognize in real life (not a demographic)?
- If I removed age, major, or job title, would the role still make sense?
- Would someone else describing this role picture the same type of person?

Undergraduate managing multiple deadlines is clearer than *college student*.

Produce well-reasoned, defensible work they feel confident submitting without second-guessing their logic

- **Primary goal**

- What is this person trying to achieve *right now*?
- What does success look like from their perspective?
- What outcome would make them feel relieved or confident?
- Is this goal about value, not features or tools?
- Could this goal remain the same even if the solution changed?

Make confident decisions about what to work on next vs. *use a planning app*.

- **Context of use**

- When does this problem usually show up?
- What triggers the moment of frustration or uncertainty?
- What else is happening around the user at that time?
- Is the user rushed, distracted, stressed, or multitasking?
- Is this a recurring situation or an occasional one?

Between classes with limited time is more useful than *during the day*.

While actively writing or revising an academic argument between classes or late at night, the user realizes they have not fully challenged their own assumptions or considered strong opposing views.

- **Key pain points**

- What specifically makes this situation hard for the user?
- Where does the user feel stuck, uncertain, or overwhelmed?
- What are the consequences of making the wrong decision?
- What emotions are present (stress, anxiety, frustration)?
- Why can't the user easily solve this today?

Uncertainty about priorities leads to procrastination and rushed work.

Difficulty identifying bias and weak reasoning leads to overconfidence, procrastination, and ultimately rushed or shallow arguments.

- **Constraints**

- What limits the user's time, attention, or energy?
- What external pressures influence their behavior?
- What tradeoffs does the user have to make?
- What resources are *not* available to them?
- What assumptions would be unrealistic to make about this user?
- **Common constraint categories:**
 - Time
 - Cognitive load
 - Access to information
 - Competing priorities

Limited time, high cognitive load, and lack of immediate access to rigorous intellectual pushback prevent the user from effectively stress-testing their ideas.

Before you start your customer journey map, ask yourself these questions.

Identify the journey.

- Who is my primary user (persona) for this journey?
- What is the single scenario I'm mapping (one sentence)?
- What is the problem the user is trying to solve in this scenario?
- What does "success" look like for the user in this scenario?

Identify the trigger. What starts the journey?

- What event causes the user to notice the problem right now?
- What makes this moment urgent or relevant?
- What does the user do first (not what your product does)?
- What is the user feeling or thinking at this moment?

Triggers are often: deadlines, confusion, reminders, mistakes, interruptions, request from someone else.

When the LLM acknowledges it is ready for questions, ask about your persona **role**.

Review my persona role. Is the role defined clearly enough that two people would picture the same type of user? Where is the role vague or overly broad?

Does this role clearly explain why this person encounters the problem? Where is that connection weak?

Make edits to your template as necessary.

When you are happy with your persona role, move on to **primary goal**.

Review my persona's primary goal. Is the primary goal stated in terms of user value rather than features or tools? Where does it drift toward solutions?

Could this goal remain the same even if the product were implemented in a different way? If not, why?

Make edits to your template as necessary.

When you are happy with your persona role, move on to **context of use**.

Review my persona's context of use. Does the context of use feel realistic and specific? What details are missing that would help someone imagine the situation?

What event or condition triggers this user to experience the problem? Is that trigger clearly stated?

Make edits to your template as necessary.

When you are happy with your persona role, move on to **pain points**.

Review my persona's pain points. Are the pain points concrete and behavior-based, or are they vague labels? Where could they be more specific?

Make edits to your template as necessary.

When you are happy with your persona role, move on to **constraints**.

Review my persona's constraints. Do the listed constraints realistically limit this user's ability to solve the problem? Which constraints feel missing or overstated?

Make edits to your template as necessary.

When you are happy with your persona role, move on to **consistency**.

Do the role, goal, context, pain points, and constraints describe the same person? Where do they feel inconsistent?

Does this persona try to represent too many user types at once? Where could it be narrowed?

What assumptions am I making about this user's behavior, motivation, or environment that are not stated explicitly?

What questions would someone unfamiliar with this product ask about this persona?

Make edits to your template as necessary.

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When you are happy with your final persona, upload your edited version and ask the LLM to read the new file and do a final quality check.

I have attached an edited final copy of my persona. Please let me know when you have read it and are ready for my questions.

What questions would someone unfamiliar with this product ask about this persona?

What kinds of product decisions could be made confidently. What would still be unclear?

When you are happy with your final persona, create a one-pager. Attach your final personal draft and try a prompt similar to this.

Act as a product management thinking partner.
Do not invent or modify any persona details.
Do not propose features, tools, or solutions.

I attached a completed user persona. Your task is to format this information into a clean, professional one-page persona summary suitable for a product review.

Use only the information I provide.

The one-pager should include:

- A clear persona name
- A short role summary
- Primary goal
- Context of use
- Key pain points
- Constraints

Add a single, realistic stock-style photo description that visually represents the persona (e.g., age range, environment, posture), but do not add new biographical details.

The layout should be concise, readable, and appropriate for a business or classroom setting.

Create a customer journey map for a single, specific problem scenario.

Before you start your customer journey map, ask yourself these questions.

Identify the journey.

A student actively forming and defending an academic argument. The user is revising an argumentative paper shortly before a deadline and is unsure whether their reasoning can withstand opposing viewpoints. They need to determine whether their argument is logically sound or if it relies on unchecked assumptions or bias. The user feels confident submitting their work knowing it has been rigorously challenged and strengthened.

Identify the trigger. What starts the journey?

A looming deadline or instructor feedback makes the user realize their argument may be weak or insufficiently challenged.

Awareness. What does the user realize or consider?

The user recognizes they need strong counterarguments and clearer reasoning but is unsure what opposing perspectives exist or how valid they are.

Decision. How does the user choose what to do?

The user decides whether to invest time critically reworking their argument or take a shortcut by submitting work that feels “good enough.”

Action. What do they actually do?

The user skims sources, mentally argues with themselves, or relies on agreeable AI tools, often stopping once time pressure outweighs confidence.

Outcome. What happens immediately after?

The user submits the work feeling temporary relief but lingering uncertainty about its rigor, as the original concern about unchallenged reasoning is only partially resolved and may resurface in future assignments.

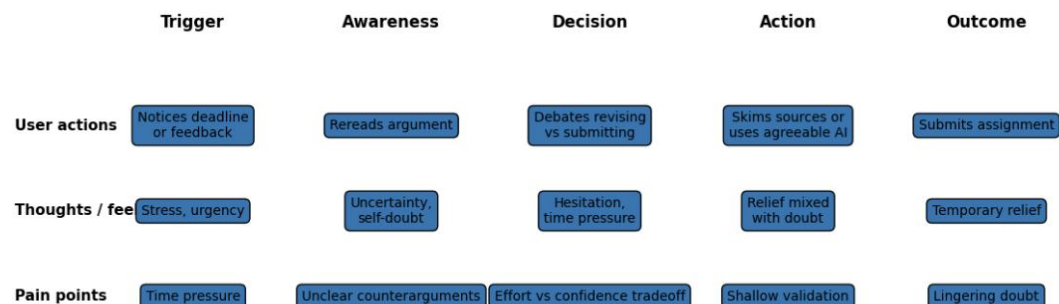
- What happens right after the action?
- Does the user feel relief, frustration, or uncertainty?
- Did the action actually reduce the original pain?
- What new problem appears (if any)?

Draw the journey map

Choose a free tool to create your diagram. Consider:

- <https://www.draw.io>
- <https://lucidchart.com>

Draw and label your swim lanes.



Add narrative descriptions of user activities, chronologically from left to right.

Start with the trigger and move right.

Go back and add what was happening immediately before the trigger.

Add the emotion curve. Add context.

Make sure your descriptions are concrete and empathetic.

- “I don’t know what to do first.”
- “If I pick wrong, I’ll miss the deadline.”

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- “I’ll do the easiest thing and hope it works.”

Save your customer journey map to a PDF file that can be uploaded to AI.

Use a LLM to question, clarify, and improve your customer journey map.

Again, let's use AI as a thinking partner to finalize our customer journey map. Pick your favorite LLM. Create a new chat and give it an opening prompt and attach your product description document from last week, your final persona template from above and a draft customer journey map.

Act as a product management thinking partner.
Do not propose solutions, features, tools, or technologies.
Do not redesign the journey.
Your role is to evaluate clarity, realism, completeness, and internal consistency.
I have attached a draft of my customer journey map as well as my product description document and user persona. Please let me know when you have read it and are ready for my questions.

When the LLM acknowledges it is ready for questions, check for missing steps.

Review my customer journey map. Does this journey feel complete from trigger to reflection? Where might steps, transitions, or moments be missing?

Make edits to your journey map as necessary.

When you are happy with edits, ask about customer awareness and decisions.

Does this journey adequately capture how the user becomes aware of the problem and decides what to do, or does it jump too quickly to action?

Make edits to your journey map as necessary.

When you are happy with edits, ask about before, during, and after balance in your map.

Is the journey balanced across before, during, and after the problem experience? Which part is underdeveloped?

Make edits to your journey map as necessary.

When you are happy with edits, ask about clarity of your map.

Is each stage written clearly enough that someone unfamiliar with the product could understand what the user is experiencing?

Do the stages feel meaningfully different from one another or do some stages blur together?

Where does the journey rely on vague language instead of concrete thoughts or actions?

Make edits to your journey map as necessary.

When you are happy with edits, ask about accuracy and realism.

Does this journey reflect how a real person would behave under time pressure, distraction, or uncertainty?

Where does this journey assume the user is more rational, organized, or motivated than they likely are?

Are the user's constraints (time, attention, resources) reflected consistently across the journey?

Make edits to your journey map as necessary.

When you are happy with edits, ask about persona alignment.

Is this journey fully consistent with the persona's role, goals, context, and pain points? Where do they feel misaligned?

Is this journey focused on a single, well-defined scenario or does it try to represent multiple situations at once?

Make edits to your journey map as necessary.

When you are happy with edits, make final checks.

Where does this journey imply solutions instead of describing experience?

If this journey map were shown in a product review, what questions would a product manager ask next?

Deliverables

1. **Persona *draft*** (before using AI): *hawkid_persona_draft.docx*
2. **Persona *final*** (after using AI): *hawkid_persona.docx*
3. **Customer journey map *draft*** (before using AI): *hawkid_cjm_draft.docx*
4. **Customer journey map *final*** (after using AI): *hawkid_cjm.docx*

Product description template

Product Name:

Problem Statement:

(What pain or difficulty is the user experiencing?)
[User] needs a way to [goal] because [pain point].

Primary User:

(Who is this product for?)
A [role] who is trying to [goal] in [context].

User Context:

(When and why does the user encounter this problem?)

Product Vision:

(What problem does this product exist to solve?)
This product helps [user] [do something meaningful] so that [positive outcome].

In Scope:

-
-

Explicitly Out of Scope:

-
-

Success:

What success looks like for the user.

-
-

What success looks like for the product.

-
-

North Star Metric:

(One metric that best represents product success)

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No dashboards, tools, or implementations—definitions only.

Supporting Metrics:

(Two supporting metrics that

-
-

No dashboards, tools, or implementations—definitions only.